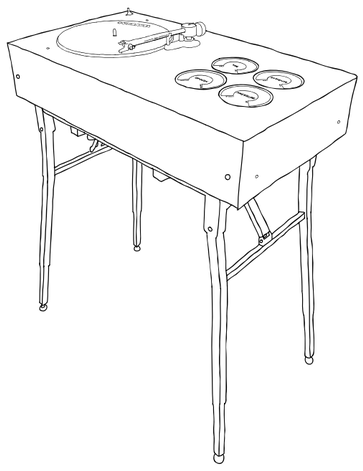
FIELDGUIDE

FIND PLAY MAKE



LONDON DESIGN FESTIVAL

FIELDGUIDE IS AN OCCASIONAL COLLECTIVE AND SOMETIMES JOURNAL FOR PEOPLE INTERESTED IN DESIGN, TECHNOLOGY AND SOCIETY AND THE INTERSECTIONS WHERE THEY OVERLAP.

OUR MOTTO IS: FIND PLAY MAKE.

IT UNDERPINS OUR WORK. WE CELEBRATE PROCESS AND OUTCOME, UNCOVERING INSIGHTS THROUGH INVESTIGATION; PLAYING WITH IDEAS AND TECHNOLOGY TO DISCOVER NEW OPPORTUNITIES; AND MAKING ENGAGING, ENTERTAINING, AMUSING AND AMAZING ARTIFACTS THAT TELL THEIR OWN STORIES AND ENCOURAGE CONVERSATION.

THE LONDON DESIGN FESTIVAL ISSUE IS THE SECOND IN A SERIES OF OCCASIONAL FIELDGUIDE PUBLICATIONS.

START

For London Design Festival, Fieldguide has brought together a mix of our friends who are designers, technologists, artists, musicians and journalists to show some of their work from the last year.

The work is new, experimental; sometimes as product, sometimes as prototype, often a work in progress, but always something that excites us about the spaces between design, technology and society.

As Brendan says "This is not a network of machines… but a network of people". To put it more boldly: we want to put people and the way they live their lives at the heart of how we think about emerging technologies, about the way the internet could evolve and the way that we fundamentally connect to people.

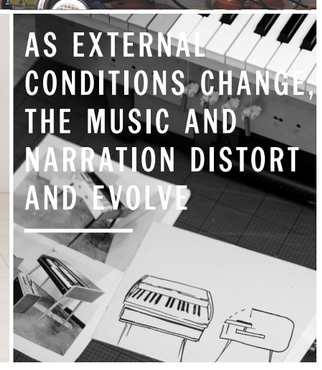
The materiality of things that are immaterial such as electricity, sound, light, emotions and the internet are incredibly important to us. This is why we are delighted to have our friends show you their explorations with paper, with conductive inks, with glass, with 7" vinyl, with storytelling and with journalism.

We hope that as you read this, listen, touch or play with the work in the show that you will begin to question the very basics of what technology really means.

Jon







INSIGHT JOURNALISM



Developed through the interdisciplinary research project Bespoke, 'Insight Journalism' re-envisions and reinterprets journalistic practice. Working within a small community in Preston, cross-disciplinary researchers both helped and supported members of the community produce a range of editorial material, spanning film, text, photography and audio. These stories - published both in a printed paper and online - provided 'insights' for teams of academics based in Dundee, Falmouth, Newcastle and Surrey. Physical designs and artefacts were inspired, made and deployed in response to these insights.

Following this stage, the project's Insight Journalists then came into their own. They reported - with impartiality and with a critical perspective - on the designs' successes and failures, which provided fresh, relevant and timely insights for the design teams involved. This allowed further refinement or re-imagining of the designs, and in some cases led to their demise.

Insight Journalism has evolved into a method for groups, communities, organisations and corporations to prompt insights and action. And to monitor the result of those actions. This circular and self-contained motion of storytelling > insight > build > storytelling offers a fresh take on how journalism as the fourth estate can be empowered to prompt change.

John Mills is a researcher, lecturer, editor and writer currently based at the University of Central Lancashire (UCLan). Over the last few years he has worked on cross-disciplinary projects that examine and innovate within and beyond the journalistic sphere. These projects range from developing mobile reporting tools for journalists in the field, supporting and training individuals to report on their local communities and examining how new technologies can evolve traditional journalistic practice. Prior to joining UCLan, John ran editorial teams in London, Manchester, Leeds and virtually.





LIQUIDITY

Liquidity is a new set of imaginative, exploratory table lamps marrying the modern material technology of conductive ink with hand blown glassware.

Inspired by the potential of Bare conductive ink, and curious to explore an alternative use for this new material, designer Patrick Stevenson-Keating aimed to exploit its properties in its crude liquid form.

The fluid nature of the ink creates a wonderfully playful and subtly charming interaction, whereby tilting the lamps makes/breaks the circuit as the ink flows between the metal contacts. This is a true visual representation of basic electronics at work, as well as being a beautiful piece in its own right.

Every element of the Liquidity project has been carefully handcrafted. After coating the inside of the glass with a hydrophobic solution, transparent oil is added to act as an insulating substance. A measure of liquid conductive ink is then inserted, forming the switch contact. The oil allows the ink to remain liquid, and ensures the ink stays in its globular form.

The bulb holder had to be hand made from custom rubber bungs, allowing standard ES screw type bulbs to be used.

Graduating last year from the Dundee Product Design course, Patrick Stevenson-Keating works from his Shoreditch based studio on exploratory design at the edge of todays society.

Much of his work deals with modern scientific or technological ideas, and how the use of design can communicate, exploit or challenge these. Creating pieces which communicate or illustrate cutting edge ideas to the public, using design to make tangible the intangible.

In addition to his own studio practice, Stevenson-Keating is an associate at international design firm Superflux, and works for Cambridge based printed electronics company Novalia.

#UNRAVEL

#UNRAVEL an interactive storytelling installation by FOUND + Aidan Moffat on the reliability of memory. As external conditions change, the music and narration distort and evolve.

#UNRAVEL follows on from previous work by FOUND (namely their popularity-obsessed, emotional robot band, Cybraphon).

However the main inspiration for the project was Creative Scotland's invitation to submit a proposal for their Vital Spark Awards.

To our knowledge no one has ever built an interactive storytelling machine quite like #UNRAVEL. The stories inside the installation change depending on what's going on at the time you place the needle on one of the ten 7" records.

If you visit #UNRAVEL early on a sunny morning you will hear very different versions of the stories compared to turning up late on a stormy evening.

The audience can also influence what they hear just by standing beside the installation, and if they really want to have an impact they can tweet their thoughts of the project using the #UNRAVEL hashtag.

If they say nice things they will increase the confidence of the narrator, if they say nasty things he will become insecure and he will remember things differently.

FOUND don't really know what we're doing when it comes to technology so #UNRAVEL was built with a lot of trial and error over a 12 month period.

FOUND are an Edinburgh-based art collective and band whose members include Ziggy Campbell, Simon Kirby, Tommy Perman, and Kev Sim. They divide their time between playing gigs, releasing records and exhibiting weird and wonderful installations. They are perhaps best known for creating a BAFTA winning emotional robot band called Cybraphon

Aidan Moffat is a Glasgow-based musician and writer. He is best known for being one half of seminal Scottish Indie band Arab Strap and recently won the first ever Scottish Album of the Year Award for "Everything's Getting Older" – a collaboration with jazz pianist
Bill Wells.

OUTSIDERS



Outsiders is a printed photograph that connects to the internet. You can touch the paper to hear the stories behind the work of photojournalist Garry Cook.

Connecting paper to the internet is incredible – think of the possibilities of paper that ranges from worthless throwaway items to priceless works that document our histories.

We're excited to be working on what possibilities printed electronics provides to the news and journalism industries to give people authentic voices to the world. We love the fact that you can now make posters that are PaperApps.

It harnesses printed electronics technology provided by Novalia to enable you to touch the paper and wirelessly connect to the web.

The photographs are taken from Garry Cook's book, Outsiders, where he examines what it means to be an outsider and how we judge others through prejudice, appearance and ignorance.

Interactive Newsprint is an RCUK funded research project that is exploring the early stage potential of printed electronics technology for the newspaper and journalism industry.

It is a consortium of researchers from the University of Central Lancaster, the University of Dundee, the University of Surrey and the technology company Novalia ltd. In this work the Interactive Newsprint team collaborated with the photojournalist Garry Cook.

HAPPINESS MACHINE

The Happiness Machine is an Internet connected printer that prints random happy or sad thoughts by random people from across the web.

It's all too easy to forget that behind that Twitter name or that Blog post is an actual real person.

The Happiness Machine, by placing a small piece of paper in your hands with the feelings of someone you've never met, reminds us that this isn't a network of machines but more importantly a network of human beings.

The future of connected objects isn't just about screens. In many ways paper is actually less throwaway than the display of pixels on a display. Combine paper with a network such as the Internet and you have a light-weight, flexible connected 'display' that you can carry anywhere, share, keep, scribble on or even reuse.

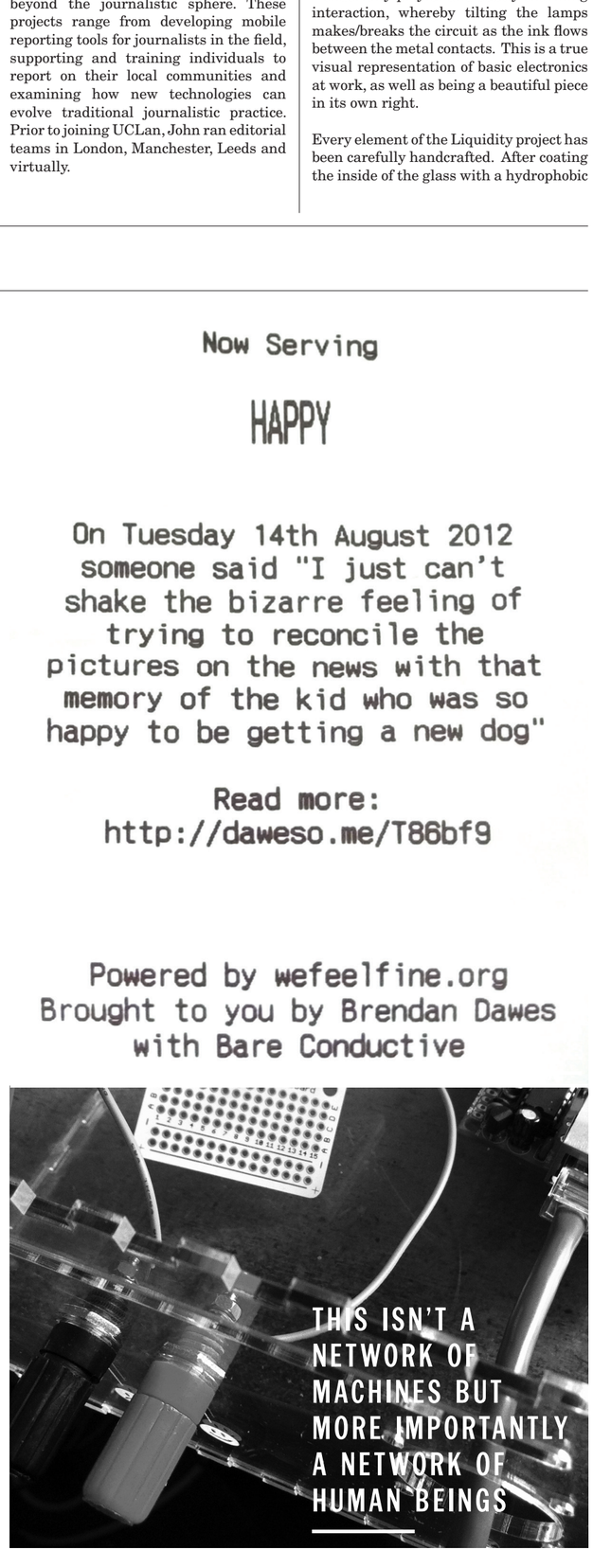
At the heart of The Happiness Machine is an Arduino compatible micro controller called a Nanode. The difference with the Nanode compared to Arduino is the former has an Ethernet connection built in, so you can connect it to the Internet without any other accessories.

The thermal printer connects to the Nanode and then two capacitive touch buttons, created using Bare Conductive's Bare Paint, trigger the Nanode to go and get either happy or sad thoughts from wefeelfine.org.

The box was laser cut using an interference fit meaning there was no need for screws or even glue - it simply pushes together, but more importantly also pulls apart.

This is an important part of the project; the clear acrylic box reveals the inner workings instead of hiding it away and everything – including the box itself – can be easily taken apart, studied and reused in other projects.

Brendan Dawes is a digital artist, designer, author and maker. Ever since his first experiences with the humble ZX81 back in the early eighties, Brendan has continued to explore the interplay of people, code, design and art through his work and on brendandawes.com, a personal space where he publishes ideas, toys and projects created from an eclectic mix of digital and analog objects.





POSTCARD PLAYER

Postcard Player is a work in progress that allows users to access and interact with cloud based audio services using paper postcards.

The player was originally conceived as a platform to illustrate what the impact of Paper Apps could be for the music industry. It was inspired by a love of rummaging through vinyl in dusty shops and half held memories of analog audio cassettes. In our first version we gave digital tracks a low cost physical form where each postcard represented a track held locally on the device. The cards were docked in the player and users could control the playback of the tracks by pressing printed buttons

This new version is slightly different – it connects to the Internet, which means each postcard becomes like a physical version of a digital bookmark! Placing one card in the player will play live radio; another will play the most popular tracks on SoundCloud and so on.

Our current screen-based interfaces are reductive – a singular way to experience a vast variety of media and information, we don't think the future will be neat like this.

Paper Apps are forerunners to a maximalist internet, where we can pick and choose the kind of interactions we want to have with data, services and each other and the objects that will deliver these.

Combining paper and conductive inks with open source digital tools like Arduino creates a powerful, accessible platform to experiment and offers an enormous opportunity to redefine and craft the medium through which we engage with digital data. By doing so we can make bespoke, more personal Internet experiences.

The postcards are laser printed and then screen printed with Bare Conductive paint. The Postcard Player uses a Raspberry Pi to connect to the Cloud and an Arduino to process the inputs from the Bare Paint. This time around we've put some LEDs on there too to provide some feedback for users as querying Internet content is proving a little sluggish at the moment.

Martin Skelly and Pete Thomas are designers at Uniform. They head up Uniform's innovation platform and experiment with connecting people to technology by creating working prototypes that excite and inspire.

FIELDNOTES

Arduino
An open-source electronics prototyping platform based on flexible, easy-to-use hardware and software.

Bare Paint
Electronically conductive paint created by Bare Conductive.

Cloud
The space where we store and interact with data online but also a physical construct made up of rooms of servers spread all over the globe, the equivalent of a very large external hard drive to which we all have access.

Conductive Ink
Ink that can carry an electrical charge. When applied to a substrate it can act as a wire.

Insight
A comprehensive uncovering of information, or the smallest inspiration garnered through consuming stories, which in turn inspires action.

Insight Journalist
Whether conducting investigative journalism or voluntary citizen reporting, Insight Journalists provide revelations, learning points and 'insights' that organisations, communities, individuals and collectives can respond to.

Nanode
An Arduino compatible board with built in Ethernet, created by Ken Boak.

The Fourth Estate
Coined in the 1800s, the term describes the media's role in society: holding the powerful to account, entertaining and informing the public and facilitating public debate.

Maximalist Internet
Defined by the richness and variety of the experiences, tools and interfaces through which we interact with it. The successor to our current Internet, which is accessed through a limited number of interactions defined by screen-based computer interfaces.

Paper Electronics
Using conductive inks and paper to create paper circuit boards.

Raspberry Pi
A $25 credit-card sized computer that can be used to do loads of the stuff that you'd normally use a PC for. www.raspberrypi.org

Thermal Printing
A digital printing process which produces a printed image by selectively heating coated thermochromic paper, or thermal paper as used in most till receipt printers.

Vinyl
Small black plastic discs that have sound waves physically etched onto their surface. They become dusty and scratched but hold a reliable recording for decades.

NEXT

There are a few upcoming Fieldguides and we're looking for contributors.

We're going to get up close and digital exploring the world of Physical Apps to try and pin down just exactly what they are.

Widening the net, we're going global with an India special to ponder the role of design and technology in the world's largest democracy.

And looking further still we'll be going a bit Brian Cox and thinking about what the future holds for Space - and if it's not a big floating orbital habitat - we'll be disappointed.

If you have something you would like to share with us on any of those issues, we'd love to hear from you, get in touch!

www.findplaymake.com

THANKS

Thanks to FOUND + Aidan Moffat, Patrick Stevenson Keating, Brendan Dawes, Matt Johnson at Bare Conductive, Martin Skelly at Uniform, John Mills and Garry Cook for coping with the madness, being up for the whole thing and providing the clever bits and the stuff what looks good. Thanks again to lovely Michelle Ford for sorting all the print out!

Thanks to Toby who prompted us to move just that little bit faster.

Patrick would like to say thanks to Matt and Bibi from BARE Conductive, and John from Orbic Glass.

#UNRAVEL was created with investment from Creative Scotland's Vital Spark Programme and New Media Scotland's Alt-w Fund, with support of the Centre for Design Informatics, Glasgow International Festival of Visual Art, SWG3 and The University of Edinburgh.

Thanks to Brompton Design District for inviting us to take part and Dewars for their enthusiasic and generous supply of the best single cask whisky in the world.

Thanks finally to Interactive Newsprint without whom this exhibition couldn't have happened.

http://interactivenewsprint.org

SUPPORTERS

Uniform

FEDRIGONI

Printed on Oikos 80gsm
Paper supplied by Fedrigoni Paper UK


#UNRAV
Project